

Chapter 66-1

As gentle as Liang Shi was, even when extremely angry, she would only say through gritted teeth—don't provoke me.

These words carried an indescribable, ambiguous meaning.

They even sounded somewhat like a coquettish complaint when they reached Xu Qingzhu's ears.

She tilted her head back, her neckline delicate and smooth, her skin milky white, her body emanating a faint fragrance. The scents intertwined in the air.

Liang Shi stood backlit, her long hair draped at her sides, with a few disobedient strands crossing over her ears to cover the side of her face.

Xu Qingzhu's back was against the door, and through her thin clothing, she could still feel the coolness.

While the Alpha's body radiated warmth.

It was truly a world of ice and fire.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly chuckled softly, tilting her head to look at Liang Shi. "So you're angry, then what?"

Her voice rose at the end, as if she was certain that Liang Shi wouldn't do anything to her.

Liang Shi's body continued to lean forward, their bodies almost pressed together. Liang Shi moved close to her ear and said word by word: "Teacher Xu, even a cornered rabbit will bite."

"Bite where?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "....."

Suddenly, Xu Qingzhu buried her head in the crook of Liang Shi's neck, her nose twitching, those beautiful lips brushing across Liang Shi's skin.

It cooled the heat on her skin but ignited a fire in her heart.

The restlessness rising from the depths of her heart couldn't be suppressed no matter what, like throwing a spark onto a barren grassland—it caught fire instantly and spread easily.

Liang Shi licked her lips, exhaled lightly, and held her breath.

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu withdrew at the right moment, rubbing her nose. "Ling Dang was right, Teacher Liang really does smell nice."

Liang Shi: "....."

After saying this, Xu Qingzhu gently pushed her. "Rabbit Liang, if you're not going to bite anyone, go downstairs and hold the child, so you'll have somewhere to use your energy."

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi ground her teeth, unable to hold back.

She turned her face and gently bit Xu Qingzhu's neck, immediately withdrawing.

Her warm, moist lips had only just touched the skin on the side of her neck—there was no real harm done.

But she really did bite—someone.

Xu Qingzhu's expression froze, and whatever she was about to say was completely forgotten.

Her mind went blank for a few seconds, but she instinctively licked her lips.

That vampire thought from before sprouted up again like bamboo shoots after rain, and she swallowed.

—Gulp.

In the quiet night, it sounded particularly clear.

Liang Shi said through gritted teeth: "Teacher Xu, I really will bite."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Omegas were naturally sensitive to an Alpha's touch. When Liang Shi had just leaned over, Xu Qingzhu's body felt as if an electric current had passed through it, carrying a tingling, itchy sensation, as if one more step forward and she would melt into a pool of warm, soft water.

Liang Shi's long hair still hung down in front of Xu Qingzhu's chest, like gentle waves softly brushing past.

Xu Qingzhu's heartbeat quickened rapidly.

Her hand instinctively gripped the door.

But Liang Shi immediately stood up straight. "I'm going to hold the child."

After saying this, she fled in panic as if wolves were chasing her.

Xu Qingzhu stared at that flustered retreating figure and noticed her ear tips were red enough to drip blood.

—Tsk, want to bite.

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes and tilted her head back, knocking it against the door.

Really, what was she thinking?

Xu Qingzhu reached up to pinch her own earlobe—it was ridiculously hot.

This unfamiliar emotion left her feeling somewhat at a loss.

Sometimes she acted on instinct, doing certain things, saying certain words, and afterward when she thought back on it...

It didn't seem quite appropriate.

But her heart would feel nervous, yet also tinged with sweetness.

Xu Qingzhu let out a soft sigh. This was too complicated.

It wasn't an emotion that she, a science and engineering woman¹, could understand.

But she seemed... not to dislike it.

If she had time, she might have the inclination to investigate it thoroughly.

But for now, she chose to let things take their natural course.

Footnotes:

¹ Science and engineering woman (理工女): A Chinese term referring to women who study or work in STEM fields (Science, Technology, Engineering, Mathematics). The stereotype suggests they are more logical and analytical, less experienced with or understanding of emotional and romantic matters compared to those in liberal arts or humanities fields.

Chapter 66-2

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When Liang Shi went downstairs, she was flustered and disoriented, even walking with the same hand and foot moving together¹.

The living room was spacious, and without Xu Qingzhu's faint fragrance lingering around her nose, she finally leaned against the stairs and took several deep breaths.

Liang Shi closed her eyes, and only then did she feel a bit better.

She covered her chest with one hand—her heart was pounding there, as if it was about to jump out.

Completely beyond her control.

Between her lips and teeth, Xu Qingzhu's scent seemed to linger, especially the sensation on her teeth—even though it was just a moment, it was particularly distinct.

Even recalling it made her swallow.

She just... really wanted to bite down again.

To retract her teeth.

To touch with the tip of her tongue.

Or to use her lips to touch that patch of skin—it would probably feel even more comfortable.

.....

Stop.

Liang Shi tapped her forehead, stopping those lingering thoughts.

What was she thinking?

Her two long, straight legs felt somewhat weak now, and she had to lean against the stairs to feel a bit better, so she wouldn't fall down.

Once her heartbeat calmed down, she looked up at the second floor.

Even a single glance was enough to make her heart race.

Mainly because just now...

Liang Shi felt her behavior was inexplicably childish.

Yet at that moment, she had still done it.

Forget it, better not to think about it.

Thinking too much would make her want to bang her head on the ground.

Afraid that Ling Dang would roll onto the floor, Xu Qingzhu had placed a pillow beside her to block her.

And Ling Dang's little hand was resting on the pillow. In her dream, she seemed to be eating something, her mouth constantly smacking, as if having a sweet dream. Her whole face was turned upward, and she was about to roll over, rolling directly onto the pillow. Liang Shi immediately caught her with quick reflexes.

One foot had already dropped to the floor.

Liang Shi quickly picked her up. Ling Dang's head rested on her shoulder, her body soft and limp.

Holding a little girl was just so soft and comfortable.

She carried Ling Dang upstairs. Xu Qingzhu had already made the bed, with Ling Dang sleeping in the middle as usual.

Footnotes:

¹ Same hand and foot moving together (同手同脚): A Chinese idiom describing someone walking awkwardly or clumsily, with the same-side hand and foot moving forward simultaneously instead of alternating. It indicates being flustered, nervous, or uncoordinated.

Chapter 66-3

Not long after, Liang Shi received a video call from Liang Xinhe.

The two chatted for a bit, mainly asking if Ling Dang was being good. But when they looked, Ling Dang was already asleep, not missing her mom and dad at all. Liang Xinhe couldn't help but say, "Little heartless one."

Liang Shi smiled helplessly.

Liang Xinhe reminded her to go to bed early, and only at the end did she ask: "After you drop Ling Dang off tomorrow, stay at home for dinner with your sister-in-law¹."

Liang Shi's smile froze, and she said somewhat awkwardly: "If we're there, won't it be awkward to eat?"

"What's awkward about it?" Liang Xinhe frowned, speaking carelessly: "Do you still have the surname Liang or not?"

Liang Shi: "The way you put it, I can't change my surname in such a short time."

"Then that's settled." Liang Xinhe said: "Bring Qingzhu along too. It's our own home anyway, what's wrong with having a meal?"

Liang Shi couldn't refuse anymore and had to agree. "Alright."

After she finished the call with Liang Xinhe, Xu Qingzhu received a call from Mother Xu, speaking in low tones about who knows what.

Xu Qingzhu was afraid of disturbing Ling Dang's sleep, so she went out to take the call.

She didn't return until much later.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi sat at the head of the bed in a daze, contemplating whether to go downstairs to sleep or stay here.

Before she could think of an answer, Xu Qingzhu returned to the room. She removed her hair tie, letting her hair fall loose, and took off her outer cardigan, wearing only a slip dress.

Her arms didn't have an ounce of excess flesh, her collarbones were delicate, and the loose slip dress didn't make her look excessively thin.

Liang Shi only glanced once before making her decision: go downstairs.

She didn't dare take the blanket or pillow, afraid that this mischievous little one would wake up in the middle of the night and wail. She just planned to go downstairs and get new ones to make do.

But before she could leave, Xu Qingzhu asked: "Where are you going?"

"Going downstairs to sleep." Liang Shi answered.

Xu Qingzhu got into bed, covered herself with the blanket, and leaned against the headboard. Taking a book from the drawer, she was casually flipping through pages when her hand suddenly paused. "What if Ling Dang wakes up in the middle of the night?"

"Just say I'm in the bathroom." Liang Shi said: "I'll come back up tomorrow morning."

"There's no need to be so troublesome." Xu Qingzhu didn't mind. "Just sleep over there. Otherwise, if Ling Dang discovers it, she'll ask all sorts of questions."

Liang Shi: "....."

It was indeed more convenient to sleep upstairs.

Liang Shi's heart swayed precariously on the scales.

In the end, she chose to compromise.

She turned off the main light in the room, leaving only the two dim, amber lamps by the bed.

The room's ambiance immediately became much more elegant.

Her long-sleeved pajamas seemed extremely conservative at this moment. As soon as she got into bed, Ling Dang rolled over and burrowed into her arms, as if sensing the warmth.

Xu Qingzhu was surprised, then said: "She seems to especially like you."

"A bit." Liang Shi was afraid of waking Ling Dang, so she lowered her voice: "Little clingy spirit."

"All little kids are like this." Xu Qingzhu glanced at Ling Dang. Before bed, Xu Qingzhu had helped her untie her hair, but this little girl's sleeping posture wasn't very good, and now her hair was plastered all over her face, which looked uncomfortable.

She simply found a small hair tie and smoothed out her hair, tying it in a very loose ponytail that wouldn't pull on her scalp or plaster hair on her face.

Liang Shi suddenly thought of something from during the day and sighed: "You can only have one child."

"Why?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Too many will fight." Liang Shi told her about Ling Dang and Rainbow's incident. After finishing, she sighed: "And that was with Rainbow being sensible. Otherwise, they would definitely have pulled each other's hair bows."

"That's just how little kids are." Xu Qingzhu said: "Don't look at how they're fighting now—they'll make up in a bit and won't even remember. It's the adults who have to be the judge. You always have to arbitrate for them, right?"

"No need." Xu Qingzhu shrugged. "The best method is to let them handle it themselves. If they like to fight, let them fight—whoever wins is fine. Anyway, before long, when no one will play with them, they'll naturally make up on their own. Adults shouldn't interfere in children's matters."

Liang Shi was puzzled. "It can be like that?"

"That's how it should be." Xu Qingzhu said matter-of-factly: "Otherwise, if your daughter gets into a fight with another kid at kindergarten later, are you going to help her fight too?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She said awkwardly, "Well, I wouldn't do that."

"You might not be sure you can hold back." Xu Qingzhu chuckled. "By then, you'll go join your daughter and tear off other kids' hair bows."

"How is that possible?" Liang Shi said helplessly. "Teacher Xu, am I that childish in your heart?"

"No, no, no." Xu Qingzhu denied three times in a row, but paused before saying: "You're just too indulgent with little kids."

Liang Shi: "....."

After a while, Ling Dang burrowed into her arms, soft and warm, a tiny little bundle.

Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu and sighed helplessly, muttering: "With such a small little kid, of course you have to dote on them."

Who wouldn't be smitten with this?

Xu Qingzhu just smiled without speaking, opening her book to read.

Xu Qingzhu under the amber lamplight was also very beautiful. She had draped a jacket over herself, and sitting there reading, she appeared serene and refined.

Liang Shi looked sideways, and before she knew it, her mind had wandered.

Footnotes:

¹ Sister-in-law (妹妻): Literally "younger sister's wife" or "younger wife," in this context referring to Xu Qingzhu as Liang Shi's wife/partner. The term reflects the familial relationship structure where Liang Shi would be considered part of the family, and Xu Qingzhu would be addressed accordingly by other family members.

Chapter 66-4

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu suddenly lifted her head from the book and turned to ask Liang Shi: "By the way, today Ling Dang said that a classmate's mother in Rainbow's class looks very similar to me."

Liang Shi's wandering thoughts were pulled back. "Hm?"

"Did you see her?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes, very similar."

Xu Qingzhu's fingers brushed across the pages of the book, and she said gently: "Ling Dang also said that little classmate is called Sheng Yu."

Liang Shi paused.

"Mm." Liang Shi tentatively continued following her words: "She also has another name, Su Yu."

"A little kid with two names." Xu Qingzhu curved her lips in a light smile, but there was no warmth in her eyes. Not knowing what she was pondering, her voice also seemed cold. "Not very common."

"Her mother said one was given by her father and one by her mother." Liang Shi watched Xu Qingzhu's expression carefully, speaking leisurely: "But the one being used now is the name her mother gave. And then..."

She paused. "Her mother is called Su Mu. You two have very similar noses and mouths. She's been wearing sunglasses the whole time, so I couldn't see how similar the eyes are."

Xu Qingzhu's hand gripping the page suddenly tightened, and the sound of the paper crinkling was exceptionally crisp.

"Surname Su..." Xu Qingzhu murmured, then smiled: "My uncle's former girlfriend seemed to have the surname Su."

"Hm?" Liang Shi played dumb. "Really? That's quite a coincidence. I remember your mother's surname is Sheng."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Yes, but there are so many people with the surname Sheng in this world, and my uncle has been dead for many years."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together: "Alright."

After that, neither of them spoke.

Before sleeping, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said: "Liang Shi, this Sunday my mom wants us to come home for dinner. Are you free?"

Liang Shi immediately responded: "Yes, I am."

"Also." Xu Qingzhu said: "This Sunday is my uncle's death anniversary. My mom wants..."

Before Xu Qingzhu could finish, Liang Shi agreed in one breath: "Of course, I'll accompany you all then."

"Okay, thank you." Xu Qingzhu let out a soft breath.

"There's no need for such small matters." Liang Shi said: "Teacher Xu, don't you also have to come back to the old residence with me tomorrow? We're helping each other out."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Alright then."

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Deep autumn brought frequent rain, and that night the rain started falling pitter-patter again.

Around two o'clock, the rain became heavy, accompanied by a few thunderclaps.

It frightened Ling Dang into whimpering a few times.

Liang Shi patted her back in her sleep, coaxing her to sleep.

But when she half-opened her eyes to look at the other side of the bed, Xu Qingzhu's phone was still lit, viewing something.

However, the rain didn't last long. By dawn it had cleared up.

When Liang Shi woke up, Ling Dang was staring at her with round eyes. Just as she smiled and was about to greet Ling Dang, Ling Dang immediately covered her mouth, making a "shh" gesture, then pointed at Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu hadn't woken yet. She must have had some nightmare, her brows tightly furrowed.

Liang Shi continued lying there holding Ling Dang. It must be said, holding a soft little kid in her arms was like holding a small warming stove.

She took out two candies from the drawer and handed them to Ling Dang.

Sure enough, Ling Dang's eyes immediately lit up.

But she first unwrapped one and fed it to Liang Shi's mouth before eating one herself.

The blanket on Xu Qingzhu's side had also slipped down, exposing her beautiful, pale, slender shoulder. Liang Shi pressed her lips together lightly, reached out with her long arm to pull the blanket up for her. But Xu Qingzhu suddenly opened her eyes, those eyes full of wariness.

It startled Liang Shi.

Seeing it was Liang Shi, Xu Qingzhu finally let out a soft breath.

Ling Dang immediately moved closer, her soft little voice saying: "Auntie¹, did you have a nightmare?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded, her arm resting over her eyes, responding weakly: "Mm."

"It's okay, it's okay." Ling Dang lay beside her, moving close to her face and giving her a kiss. "A kiss and the nightmare goes away."

Xu Qingzhu, who had been frightened by the nightmare, smiled at these words and immediately pulled Ling Dang into her arms, kissing her soft little face. "How are you so good at talking? Did you put honey on your lips?"

"No." Ling Dang blinked. "Auntie² put honey on her lips."

Liang Shi: "Huh?"

Ling Dang said: "Auntie's lips are sweet. Auntie, you can try."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Liang Shi gave her a light tap. "What are you saying?"

Ling Dang let out a soft hum. "But it's true. You just ate candy, isn't it sweet?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Xu Qingzhu was amused by her "childish words" and wanted to laugh, but deliberately put on a stern face to tease her: "You two were sneaking candy again?"

Ling Dang pressed her lips together, staring with round eyes, and without hesitation betrayed Liang Shi: "Auntie gave it to me."

Facing Xu Qingzhu's oppressive gaze, Liang Shi swallowed, then pulled out another candy from the drawer and handed it over.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I don't eat them."

Liang Shi: "....."

Then she called to Liang Shi: "Come here."

Liang Shi was stunned: "Huh?"

But her body was very honest and moved over. Xu Qingzhu held Ling Dang with one hand, and reached out with the other, her fingertip gently brushing the corner of Liang Shi's mouth.

Xu Qingzhu had just woken up, and her clear, cool voice carried a hint of hoarseness, sounding especially alluring. "Sneaking candy and not even wiping your mouth clean."

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu showed her fingertip—on it was a white candy crumb.

Liang Shi felt embarrassed.

But Xu Qingzhu let out a soft laugh, her voice lazy and casual: "Teacher Liang, how are you just like a little kid?"

Liang Shi: "....."

This was an accident!!!

Footnotes:

¹ Auntie (姑母): A formal term for paternal aunt (father's sister), which is how Ling Dang addresses Xu Qingzhu in this context.

² Auntie (姑姑): A less formal, more affectionate term for paternal aunt (father's sister), which is how Ling Dang addresses Liang Shi. The distinction in Chinese shows the different levels of closeness or formality, though both translate to "auntie" in English.

Chapter 66-5

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When Liang Shi dropped Ling Dang off, she casually bought some fruit.

Nothing expensive, she simply saw a street vendor selling oranges that were bright yellow, and the cherries also looked excellent.

She tasted one and thought they were better than what the supermarket sold, so she bought a bag of oranges and over two hundred yuan worth of cherries.

These things would probably be considered beneath notice by the Liang family.

But for Liang Shi, when going to eat at someone's house, she should always buy something as a gift in return.

And she happened to think these things were delicious, so she bought them back for everyone to try something fresh.

Imported fruits weren't necessarily better than what she bought.

Ling Dang praised the oranges enthusiastically in the car. Xu Qingzhu helped her peel one and shared it with her, even feeding a segment to Liang Shi, who was diligently playing chauffeur.

The orange lived up to its appearance—juicy and sweet.

After getting out of the car, Liang Shi carried two bags of fruit while Xu Qingzhu held Ling Dang's hand.

After returning to the old residence, Ling Dang became much more well-behaved, losing her liveliness from outside, completely transformed into a quiet and gentle little princess.

Everyone in the family was there. Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe had just come out of the study. Qiu Zimin and Father Liang were sitting on the sofa—one scrolling through an iPad reading news, the other flipping through a fashion magazine. Yu Wan and Sun Meirou, the sisters-in-law, were watching a drama on the side.

The family atmosphere was good, looking peaceful and harmonious.

It was Ling Dang who first called out: "Grandpa, Grandma, I'm back."

And so broke the peace.

Liang Xinzhou looked at Liang Shi first: "You're back."

Liang Shi nodded. "Elder Brother, Second Brother."

She stood there, appearing somewhat awkward.

Xu Qingzhu followed her, naturally not faring much better.

"You even bought fruit." Liang Xinhe clicked his tongue. "Our little Liang Shi has grown up."

Liang Shi was familiar with him and glanced at him. "I saw they looked good on the road, so I casually bought some. We can eat them as fruit after the meal."

"Don't bring just anything into the house." Qiu Zimin suddenly said coldly: "This house isn't a garbage dump. Collected garbage decades ago, and still collecting garbage now."

As soon as these words came out, the family atmosphere immediately turned cold.

Ling Dang looked up, confused: "Grandma, what does that mean?"

Qiu Zimin immediately changed her expression, crouching down to explain to Ling Dang: "It means don't pick up dirty, unclean things and bring them back to eat—you'll easily get sick."

Ling Dang frowned. "But no one in our family picks up dirty, unclean things. Everything is very clean."

"Grandma was just speaking casually." Qiu Zimin didn't want Ling Dang to know about these things, so she glossed over this matter vaguely.

But these words could fool a little child, not so many adults present. Everyone could hear the implications in her words.

Liang Shi frowned, wanting to retort, but felt that saying anything in front of so many people would make the atmosphere in this house incredibly awkward and uncomfortable.

Everyone would feel bad, so she held it in.

And Liang Xinzhou said coldly: "This house is quite clean. No one collects garbage."

Then he gestured to a servant standing nearby. "Take this fruit to the kitchen and wash it."

The servant came over and took the fruit away.

Only then did Liang Shi feel a bit better.

But correspondingly, Qiu Zimin frowned, glancing resentfully at Liang Xinzhou.

Liang Xinzhou had no reaction and continued to greet Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu, telling them to come sit down.

Yu Wan and Sun Meirou also stopped watching TV and accompanied Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Wanwan still had one more class at school today, so she would return the latest.

After she came back, the family began their meal.

The seating order was the same as before, but today was Xu Qingzhu's first time eating at the Liang family, so her seat was arranged next to Liang Shi.

At the huge table with dozens of dishes, everyone ate quietly. The villa was so quiet you could hear a pin drop.

No one made a sound.

After finishing the meal, Liang Xinzhou had the servant bring up the prepared fruit.

As soon as he finished instructing the servant, Qiu Zimin frowned and said: "Who knows if things from outside are clean or not? Those plastic bags are all toxic."

"Then you don't have to eat any." Liang Xinzhou said coldly, his glasses covering the sharp light in his eyes, but unable to suppress the cold aura emanating from him. "It's Third Sister's kind gesture. You don't have to be like this, do you?"

"You sure know how to acknowledge sisters." Qiu Zimin let out a light snort. "You don't even know where your real sister is suffering, and you don't even try to find her."

"Ah Zi." Father Liang suddenly spoke. "You just finished eating, say less."

He instructed the servant in a deep voice: "Bring up the fruit Third Miss bought."

The servant was made tense by this family atmosphere and didn't know what to do for a moment.

It was only after Father Liang spoke that she dared go to the kitchen to bring it out.

When the servant brought it up, Qiu Zimin left the dining table with a cold face.

Everyone was made quite unhappy by her.

Liang Shi's gaze swept over everyone present, and she sighed softly with a bitter smile: "I'll go talk to her."

She stood up, then her gaze fell on Father Liang. "Would you like to come along?"

"You two talk." Father Liang said: "I won't participate."

Liang Shi said nothing and got up to go upstairs.

She stood at Qiu Zimin's door and knocked several times. Qiu Zimin opened the door, and upon seeing her, her eyes revealed disgust. Then she said coldly: "What are you doing here? We have nothing to say to each other anyway. You don't acknowledge me as your mother either."

"That depends on whether you acknowledge me as your daughter." Liang Shi said. "I want to talk with you."

She didn't use any respectful terms either.

Someone like Qiu Zimin wasn't really worthy of respect.

Qiu Zimin frowned. "I have nothing to talk about with you. We finished talking last time."

Talking until she was so angry she fainted.

Chapter 66-6

Qiu Zimin's entire heart was now fixated on her own daughter. She couldn't be bothered to wrangle with Liang Shi anymore. Seeing her only filled her with intense disgust.

"But I still have things to talk about with you." Liang Shi looked at her. "For instance—Yunfeng Mountain?"

She said word by word: "Or—Yang Jiani? Or again—Zhou Yi'an?"

Qiu Zimin coldly denied: "What are you talking about? I don't understand."

"Really?" Liang Shi said: "Like you, I don't want to make things difficult for Elder Brother and Second Brother either."

"Those are not your brothers!" Qiu Zimin said sternly: "Who knows where you came from, you bastard. Don't try to claim my sons."

"Fine." Liang Shi didn't argue with her, only telling her: "Then let's close the door and talk. Otherwise, your sons might see your hysterical appearance."

Qiu Zimin glared at her, then stepped aside halfway, taking a deep breath and saying: "Say whatever you want to say, then get lost quickly. I have nothing to say to you."

Liang Shi's phone in her pocket was still lit, the screen displaying: Recording 00:04:20.

She didn't sit down, just stood there, then quietly looked at Qiu Zimin, looking until Qiu Zimin felt irritated. "If you have nothing to say, then get out. I don't want to see you."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. After a long while, she finally spoke: "Why do you hate me so much?"

Yes.

Hate.

Ten thousand times heavier than dislike.

Qiu Zimin closed her eyes. "Whenever I think of you enjoying wealth and luxury here while my daughter is still suffering somewhere in poverty, I wish I could strangle you."

"But this result wasn't my choice." Liang Shi said: "You could have chosen not to pick me up back then, to let me remain a piece of garbage, rather than picking me up and tormenting me like this."

Qiu Zimin looked at her. "Liang Shi, you've got it wrong, haven't you? I tormented you? I gave you affection, gave you wealth and luxury, and brothers who dote on you so much. Where did I torment you? Now whenever I think of my Nuan Nuan¹, my heart aches to death."

"Then what if your Nuan Nuan was also raised by others the way you raised me?" Liang Shi curved her lips in a smile that carried a hint of coldness. "Like you said, given affection, given wealth and luxury, and given doting brothers. Would you be sad?"

Qiu Zimin's breathing hitched, and she immediately said: "My Nuan Nuan would never be like you—with such a strange and twisted personality, an ungrateful wretch."

"I'm an ungrateful wretch?" Liang Shi raised an eyebrow. "Not accepting your PUA² makes me an ungrateful wretch?"

"Who's PUA-ing you!" Qiu Zimin said sternly: "Don't just learn a internet term and use it indiscriminately! Liang Shi, now you've grown up, your wings have hardened, you can turn your two brothers against me. Do you know what Liang Xinzhou said?"

"I don't really want to know." Liang Shi said.

Even if she knew, it wouldn't change anything, and would only make her feel more guilty.

"You see! You're just heartless." Qiu Zimin accused her from a moral high ground. "Your eldest brother told us not to look for our Nuan Nuan anymore. That's his real sister, and you made him so cold-blooded. What kind of poison did you feed him!"

"Believe it or not, I haven't mentioned a single word to Elder Brother about your biological daughter." Liang Shi remained calm. "I just want to ask you, why do you hate me so much?"

"I don't hate you." Qiu Zimin stubbornly stuck to this statement.

Liang Shi paused before saying: "Then why did you conspire with Daoist Yunyin³, arrange my room like a coffin, and want to use me as a sacrifice? Do you really believe in these things?"

Qiu Zimin frowned, her teeth nearly grinding to pieces, yet she denied: "I sought Daoist Yunyin to cure your illness. Back then you were so sick you couldn't even get out of bed. If it weren't for Daoist Yunyin, you would have died long ago."

"That was just a common cold. Taking medicine or getting an IV would have been fine." Liang Shi said: "Why is it that when Elder Brother, Second Brother, and Wanwan got sick, you called family doctors for them, but when it came to me, you started with feudal superstition?"

"You simply wanted to give me a room like that, didn't you?" Liang Shi analyzed in a low voice. "To crush my spirit, to make me feel I should only live in darkness, to make me feel like I'm a piece of garbage that everyone looks down on, that only you truly care for me, and thereby..."

Before she could finish the second half of the sentence about "better control me," Qiu Zimin interrupted her words. "Yes!"

Qiu Zimin glared at her viciously. "You are a piece of garbage. If I hadn't picked you up, you should be sleeping in garbage every day."

"But you could have chosen not to pick me up." Liang Shi sneered. "You picked me up to compensate for the pain of losing your daughter. My existence, to some extent, brought comfort to your spirit. You should be thanking me, right? But why did you want to drive me insane?"

"You should be a lunatic, an idiot, mentally ill, sent to a mental hospital." Qiu Zimin said: "There's no why."

Liang Shi found this too slow. She couldn't get anything out of her at all, only feeling her negative energy and endless disgust.

So she changed her tactics. "You knew Mrs. Qi had domestic violence tendencies, right?"

Qiu Zimin suddenly paused. She asked warily: "What are you trying to say?"

Liang Shi said: "Mrs. Qi, that is Yang Jiani—you have a good relationship with her? Why did you send me to her house?"

The room suddenly fell silent.

For a while, no one spoke.

After a long time, Qiu Zimin sneered: "Liang Shi, are you planning to dig up old scores now? It seems your memory is quite good—you still remember things from so many years ago."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together: "Some traumas were too severe. They're indeed hard to forget."

"So what?" Qiu Zimin said: "Do you want to settle accounts with me or with Mrs. Qi?"

"The criminal punishment for domestic violence is very light." Liang Shi said: "Besides, it's been so many years. How could there be any sentencing? Even if you took it to court, it wouldn't be accepted."

Qiu Zimin chuckled lightly. "You even looked up the law. Liang Shi, you've asked me so many 'whys,' so let me ask you one too."

She paused, her gaze instantly becoming vicious. "Why haven't you gone insane yet?"

Liang Shi revealed a gentle smile. To Qiu Zimin, this smile was piercingly glaring.

But Liang Shi said: "Perhaps, when you didn't know it, I already did go insane."

The original body had already been driven nearly mad by her.

Self-harm, sex addiction, giving up halfway on seeing a psychologist, bipolar disorder.

Basically ruined.

The current one was a different Liang Shi, one who hoped to seek justice for herself and also for the original body.

Qiu Zimin sneered lightly. "What a pity I couldn't witness your madness with my own eyes."

"That is indeed a pity." Liang Shi agreed with her words, then steered the topic back. "So you knew Yang Jiani was a habitual domestic abuser, right? Sending me there, nominally for discipline, was really just to make me suffer."

Qiu Zimin looked at her. After a moment, she smiled. "Since you've even looked up Mrs. Qi's real name, do you know or not that her daughter is already dead?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, then nodded: "So what?"

"So why would you provoke a lunatic who would personally kill her own daughter?" Qiu Zimin's expression became maniacal in an instant, looking at Liang Shi with bloodthirsty light in her eyes. "I also regret not being like Mrs. Qi and killing you early on!"

Footnotes:

¹ Nuan Nuan (囡囡): An affectionate term for a young daughter, often used in southern Chinese dialects. It literally means "little girl" and conveys endearment.

² PUA: Stands for "Pick-Up Artist" but in modern Chinese internet slang, it refers to psychological manipulation and emotional abuse tactics used to control or gaslight someone in relationships.

³ Daoist Yunyin (雲隱道長): "Daoist" is a title for a Taoist priest or master. "Yunyin" literally means "cloud hidden" or "hidden in clouds." "Daochang" (道長) is a respectful title for a Taoist priest, similar to "reverend" or "master."